Improving literacy instruction in K-3 classrooms through job-embedded coaching procedures

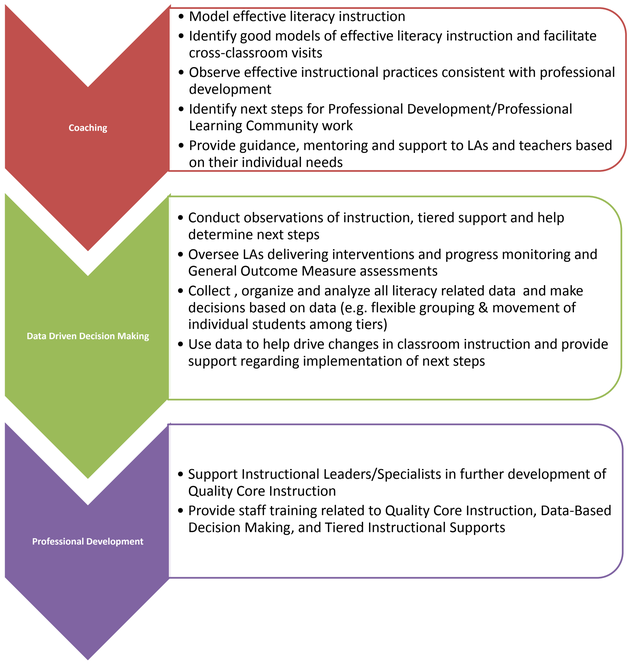
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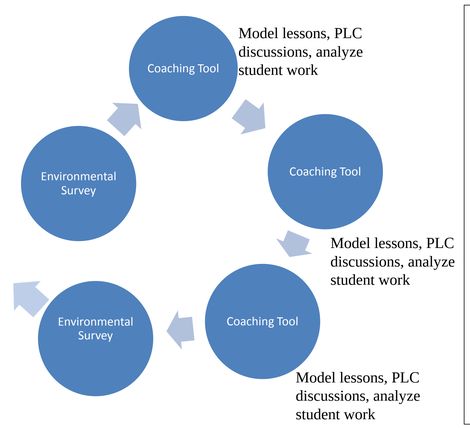
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Abstract

We share the work being done in partnership with six urban schools, a corporate sponsor, a non-profit service organization, and a university-based research center to improve student reading proficiency by third grade (Path to Reading Excellence in School Sites/PRESS). A key contributor to improved reading achievement for all students is the quality of the core instruction they experience at school. As part of the PRESS partnership, site-based literacy coaches collect environmental and instructional data and use these data to provide support for individual and grade-level teams of teachers. Coaches, with the support of university faculty, help design site-based professional development sessions and data-review meetings that assist teachers in matching their instruction to students' needs. After these group meetings, coaches follow-up in classrooms to troubleshoot implementation concerns and document instructional progress. This poster outlines the framework, processes and measures being used to support quality core instruction in early literacy, and what we are finding to be the most powerful tools for affecting instructional improvement.





Results

- Job-embedded coaching procedures have been implemented in the six sites for two academic years, following a survey-coach-coach-coach-survey structure.
- A wide variety of embedded coaching procedures have been implemented including observing and providing specific feedback to teachers, coach-modeled small and whole-group lessons, co-teaching, co-planning, consulting, organizing instructional groups, and facilitating whole-class interventions.
- Implementation of the coaching model was adjusted for individual sites based on collaborative discussions with the school leadership team, on-site curriculum resources and teacher experience, and student needs.

PRESS
Path to Reading Excellence in School Sites

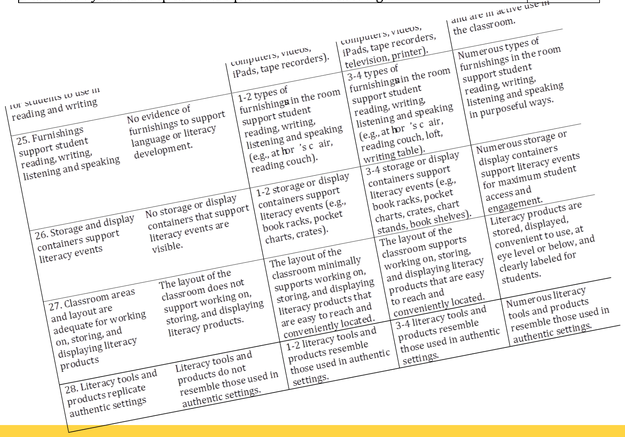
PRESS Classroom Environmental Survey

Teacher Code_____ Date _____
Grade _____ Observer _____
School _____

Part 1: Environmental Data (Collected prior to lesson observation)
Please code the extent to which each item below is present.

0=not evident, 1= a minimal presence, 2= some, 3=exemplary

1. Basic writing tools such as paper, pencils, crayons and markers	
2. Accessible writing center for students	
3. Materials available for students to publish	
4. Available writing surfaces such as paper, blank books, slates, white boards, etc.	
5. Technological resources for writing	
6. Extra consumable literacy tools (such as sharpened pencils)	
7. Classroom library consists of basic print materials such as books and magazines	
8. Classroom library is accessible to students	
9. Print materials vary in format, content, and genre	
10. Age-appropriate reference materials such as dictionaries, encyclopedias, and atlases	
11. Collection of related books	
12. Book sets at the varied reading levels of students	
13. A balance of fiction and non-fiction texts	
14. Student-authored books or journals	
15. Books on tape or computer	
16. Evidence of student independent use of classroom literacy tools	
17. Texts are displayed in the classroom	
18. Adult-authored written communications are posted (including commercially produced charts)	
19. Student-authored written communications are posted	
20. An alphabet with clear icons or alphabet strips are accessible to students	
21. A word wall is in active use	
22. Expectations for student behavior are posted	
23. The print displayed shows signs of being updated with new learning	
24. Technological resources are available for students to use in reading and writing	
25. Furnishings support student reading, writing, listening and speaking	
26. Storage and display containers support literacy events	
27. Classroom areas and layout are adequate for working on, storing, and displaying literacy products	
28. Literacy tools and products replicate authentic settings	



Introduction

- Research indicates that students benefit significantly from the instruction of expert reading teachers (e.g., Swartz, 2005; Wharten-McDonald et al., 1998), and the practice of literacy coaching helps ensure that reading teachers become expert instructors-able to teach students the literacy skills they need to learn (Elish-Piper & L'Allier, 2010).
- The expertise of teachers is strongly connected to general student achievement (e.g., Darling-Hammond, 1999; Joyce & Showers, 2002), and in particular, student achievement in reading (Elish-Piper & L'Allier, 2010; McCutcheon et al., 2002; Swartz, 2005; Wharton-McDonald, Pressley, & Hampston, 1998).
- Effective professional development (PD) is critical for the development of teacher expertise and is characterized by intensive, sustained focus on specific content-related pedagogy, and developing strong working relationships among teachers (Darling-Hammond, Chung Wei, Andree, Richardson, & Orphanos, 2009).
- Literacy coaching is one such PD method that develops the expertise of reading teachers (Elish-Piper & L'Allier, 2010; Neufield & Roper, 2003; Swartz, 2005).

Method

Participants. Participants are six school-based literacy coaches and the 81 classroom teachers with whom they work. Teachers are located in four public and two charter schools in an urban setting. In 5 out of 6 of the schools 83-93% of students received free or reduced lunch; in the sixth school 44% of students received free or reduced lunch. The population of English learners in the six schools is 0%, 15%, 31%, 49 %, 52%, 98% respectively. The school with no English learners was a school with a population of 94% Native American students. All of the schools were looking for solutions as to why their students were not meeting grade-level benchmarks, and had applied to be a part of the partnership initiative.

Measures. The goal of this project is to develop a system for supporting quality classroom instruction as one component of a multi-tiered learning support system. To measure quality core instruction, several data sources are used including a classroom environmental survey and observation of instruction (collected in the fall and spring of each school year), as well as descriptive data from a minimum of three coaching-cycle interactions conducted in fall, winter, and spring each year between the literacy coach and each participating teacher.

Procedures. To ensure job-embedded coaching procedures were put in place, a standardized set of procedures were enacted at each of the participating schools. Consistency was safeguarded through a standardized observation protocol with scoring rubric, training sessions for data collection, and the use of double raters so that 20% of surveys could demonstrate inter-rater reliability. Coaches documented issues in core instruction at monthly coaching meetings and on a weekly electronic coaching log. Coaching interactions at each site were based on monthly instructional professional development and data-analysis meetings.

Limitations

Ecological complexities make connecting achievement to changes in teaching or the classroom environment difficult. Because of site-based prioritization, there are gaps in available environmental survey and instruction data that influence our ability to document growth and change.

Future Research

Based on this exploratory work, we are using qualitative analysis to share major themes and obstacles to improving core instruction, and describe approaches that are successful in specific cases. We are also analyzing student achievement data to better understand relationships among instructional practices, the classroom environment, and student learning.

TARGET
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